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April 25, 2006

CCA/Gainesville Chapter
1503 N.W. 14th Ave.
Gainesville, FL 32606

Dear Editor:

Enclosed is an article to inform anglers regarding new regulations that standardize the way saltwater fish are measured in Florida. Our goal is to reach as many anglers as possible with this message so they understand the new fish measurement requirements which will help them comply with Florida saltwater fishing regulations.

To achieve this objective, we are asking editors of Florida fishing magazines and club newsletters to include this article in upcoming publications, preferably before July 1 when the new regulations take effect.

We appreciate your consideration of our article for your publication. Please feel free to contact me if you need additional information.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Lee Schlesinger".

Lee Schlesinger
Division of Marine Fisheries Management

ANGLING FOR A LEGAL-SIZE FISH

It's an age old question for saltwater anglers. "How do I measure the fish I caught to make sure it's legal?"

Now there's a simple way to know for sure.

Saltwater fish are divided into two categories. Fish that have "flat" or irregularly shaped tails are measured by "total length." Fish that have forked or angled tails are commonly measured by "fork length."

To set an easy standard on how to measure these fish, the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (FWC) worked with a large group of stakeholders to craft a new "total length" measurement definition.

Beginning July 1, saltwater fish that are regulated by total length must be measured by determining the straight line distance from the most forward point of the head with the mouth closed, to the farthest tip of the tail with the tail compressed or squeezed together, while the fish is lying on its side.

This method is sometimes called "squeezing" or "pinching" the fish tail, which essentially involves obtaining the maximum possible length of the fish.

"Many Florida anglers already use this approach. It is the specified method in several other states and many of our visitors assume it is a standard technique," said Mark Robson, Director of FWC's Division of Marine Fisheries Management.

"Freshwater anglers commonly pinch the tail, and all saltwater length measurements used in scientific fisheries stock assessments are converted to this standard," said Robson.

The total length measurement is used to measure the snapper and grouper family, red and black drum, snook, spotted seatrout, weakfish, tripletail, bonefish, sheepshead, flounder and a variety of aquarium species (such as angelfish).

No change has been made to “fork length” fish, which should still be measured to the rear center edge, or “V”, of the tail. They include amberjacks and rudderfish, hogfish, dolphin, cobia, mullet, bluefish, king and Spanish mackerel, permit, pompano and African pompano, and beginning July 1, gray triggerfish.

To address concerns that applying the squeezed tail method might affect the management of certain saltwater species, such as snook, the FWC has proposed adjusting the snook slot limit by one inch on the lower and upper ends of the limit, moving from 26-34 inches to 27-35 inches total length.

“This will accommodate the slight increase in length some anglers might gain by squeezing the tail and actually result in about a four percent decrease in harvest from current levels,” said Robson.

“By simplifying the way we measure saltwater fish in Florida and making the adjustment we are proposing for snook, anglers can expect uniformly enforced rules by officers in the field and a high compliance with important fisheries resource protection regulations can be achieved,” said Robson.

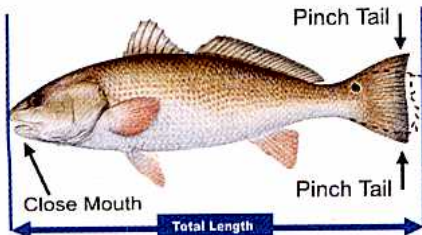
The FWC has an on-line site that explains the proper way to measure saltwater fish. Go to http://www.myfwc.com/marine/Fishing_Measurement.htm and you’ll always be sure that nice fish you hooked is a keeper – or not.

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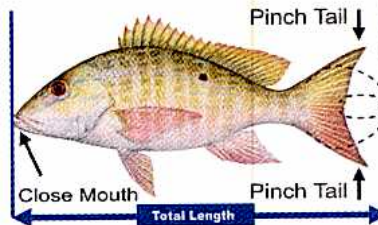
NOTE: See attached picture

Total Length

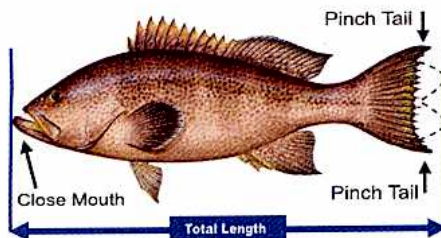
Total Length is measured from the most forward point of the head, with the mouth closed, to the farthest tip of the tail with the tail compressed or squeezed together, while the fish is lying on its side.



Red Drum



Mutton Snapper



Yellowmouth Grouper

Total Length Species Include:

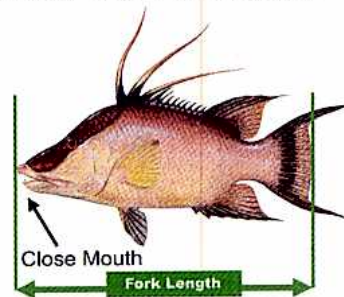
- Snapper Family
- Grouper Family
- Red Drum
- Black Drum
- Snook
- Spotted Seatrout
- Weakfish
- Tripletail
- Bonefish
- Sheepshead
- Flounder
- Several ornamentals (Angelfish, etc.,)

Fork Length

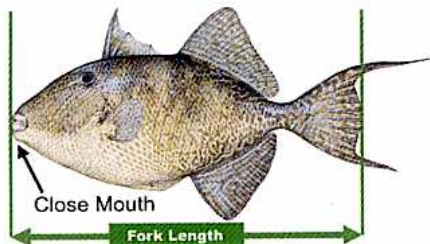
Fish regulated by fork length are measured from the tip of the jaw or tip of the snout with closed mouth to the center of the fork in the tail.



Spanish Mackerel



Hogfish



Gray Triggerfish

Fork Length Species Include:

- Amberjacks
- Rudderfish
- Hogfish
- Dolphin
- Cobia
- Mullet
- Bluefish
- King Mackerel
- Spanish Mackerel
- Permit
- Pompano
- African Pompano